

Einstein's Letter to the President Video

Assigned by: Mr. A

Due: Jun 21, 2024 11:59 PM

StudySyncTV

Scene Description

Four students sit around a table in a coffee shop. The students' books, digital devices, and notebooks are out on the table. While they talk, other students work quietly in the background.

Transcript

00:00 (INTRODUCTION PLAYS)

00:13 TROY: Hey J, you ready?

00:16 Jonathan, off with the headphones.

00:18 C'mon man have you even read the letter, that Professor Jennings just gave us?

00:22 JONATHAN: Yeah, I've read it. So?

00:24 LILA: So, I think it's incredible.

00:26 I mean Troy, you're a history major, didn't World War II start in 1939?

00:30 TROY: September 1939.

00:32 So this was written about a month before the Nazi invasion of Poland.

00:34 JONATHAN: Einstein's proposing making an Atomic bomb.

00:37 Talk about pouring gasoline on the fire.

00:40 CAROLYN: Until I read this I had no idea that Einstein kicked off the arms race.

00:44 LILA: Yeah, I thought he was a pacifist?

00:47 Or was that after the war. Can you Google that?

00:49 TROY: So, at the time of this letter Hitler's already seized Czechoslovakia,

00:52 Germany's getting ready to take revenge on basically all of Europe for World War I.

00:56 LILA: Wait a minute. Let's focus on the assignment.

00:59 Here's is what Jennings posted: 'Read Albert Einstein's letter to President Roosevelt.

01:06 Characterize the author's point of view, then respond to Einstein with a 200-word memo.

- 01 : 11 Your response should be written from you, in the present, to Einstein at the time that he wrote the letter.
- 01 : 18 JONATHAN: But how do we characterize Einstein's point of view?
- 01 : 21 CAROLYN: Did you have your headphones on in class too?
- 01 : 23 Jennings said focus on time, place, religion, profession -things like that.
- 01 : 29 TROY: I say we start by putting ourselves in Einstein's shoes.
- 01 : 32 I mean what do we really know about him what would have persuaded him to write this to the President?
- 01 : 37 Yeah, I say...I'm going to go text my roommate, and see what he has to say...
- 01 : 42 he's a history senior and knows a lot about this period.
- 01 : 45 LILA: Why don't we focus back on the words on the page.
- 01 : 49 Ok, the author was clearly smart enough that this might change the world,
- 01 : 53 so he must've chosen every single word very carefully.
- 01 : 57 I mean come on! He was Einstein!
- 02 : 00 CAROLYN: Okay, um I'm going to read this over again.
- 02 : 03 LILA: Well, why don't we all do that.
- 02 : 05 And as we read why don't we try and figure out the author's point of view
- 02 : 09 plus look for anything that we might need research later.
- 02 : 12 Good with everyone?
- 02 : 23 JONATHAN: You know, I bet this letter rocked FDR's world when he read it.
- 02 : 28 I mean FDR was a lawyer so he probably didn't know about things like nuclear fission.
- 02 : 32 TROY: Yeah, I mean atomic energy maybe, but the whole bomb thing?
- 02 : 38 Must sound like complete sci-fi.
- 02 : 40 I mean J, I bet you didn't know that H.G. Wells created the first A-bomb
- 02 : 44 in one of the stories in like 1914, huh?
- 02 : 46 JONATHAN: I bet if H.G. Wells could have designed some killer games for the Xbox,
- 02 : 50 like "The A-bomb -- Beyond Good and Evil."
- 02 : 54 LILA: Off topic guys. Let's get back to the text.
- 02 : 58 Okay everyone let's look at the first paragraph.
- 03 : 00 Einstein calls it his 'duty' to write this, he establishes himself as a good American.
- 03 : 05 And then uses his credibility as a top scientist in the world to build his case.

03:10 I'm persuaded.

03:11 CAROLYN: I'm not.

03:13 I'm not a Physics major, but 'large quantities of new radium-like elements' doesn't sound too good.

03:18 TROY: Words like that were intended to warn FDR about what was

03:21 coming in science to you know persuade him to pursue research, you know get a jump on the Nazi's.

03:26 CAROLYN: I like to think of Einstein as just a mess of white hair and warm eyes,

03:30 you know just that lovable genius type.

03:32 JONATHAN: I know, but as a German Jew,

03:34 Einstein must have been seriously aware of the threat posed if Nazi Germany got the bomb first.

03:39 TROY: Whoa, whoa, whoa guys hold on...

03:41 my roommate texts that some historians actually believe that

03:43 Leo Szilard he actually wrote the letter and it appears that Einstein just signed it.

03:50 CAROLYN: This other article says that Einstein wrote it and Szilard just edited it.

03:55 TROY: Whatever it doesn't matter. Wrote it, signed it, either way he agreed with it, right?

03:58 CAROLYN: So, pacifist or not, with the information Einstein had, what choice did he have?

04:03 JONATHAN: We always have a choice, don't we? I mean, I just don't think it's that simple.

04:08 Lila, can you summarize what we have so far?

04:11 LILA : So, um this German Jewish scientist makes the difficult moral choice

04:16 during a time of crisis to use his influence to convince the United States to build an atomic weapon.

04:22 JONATHAN: Nice summary.

04:24 CAROLYN: He's addressing two different issues , one scientific and the other political.

04:28 JONATHAN: Einstein's going farther than that,

04:30 he's actually applying the scientific method to a political crisis.

04:34 CAROLYN: Maybe that might not have been such a good idea.

04:36 LILA: But can you imagine the pressure?

04:38 I mean he knew that his opinion would carry weight,

04:41 and if FDR agreed it might change the world forever.

04:44 TROY: And it did.

04 : 46 You see, this letter here it led to the bombs that killed hundreds of thousands in Japan.

04 : 51 You know I've read some firsthand accounts on this that were just completely unreal and sickening.

04 : 56 JONATHAN: But maybe necessary.

05 : 01 LILA: Well, that's the kind of thing that informs our points of view, right?

05 : 04 I mean our grandparents had World War II, our parents had the Cold War, look at what were deal with today.

05 : 10 TROY: Right, you see this is good. We're supposed to write to Einstein from the present, right?

05 : 15 And uh...you know we basically have an advantage

05:15-05:23

05 : 18 because we've seen everything that's happened since this letter's been written.

05 : 22 So kind of like telling in the future.

05 : 24 JONATHAN: Yeah, like 911, shoe bombs, wackos trying to get weapons of mass destruction...

05 : 30 LILS: Why don't we just try and write it.

05 : 33 CAROLYN: So should we just... write him a letter?

05 : 37 LILA: Dear Albert...

The students know what happened as a result of the development of nuclear technology.